

to convince victims that their devices or accounts are compromised and that immediate action is required to prevent further damage. Here are the primary methods used:

Fake helpline numbers circulating online

One of the most common tactics involves scammers publishing fake customer service numbers on search engines, social media, and unofficial websites. When a user searches for a company's helpline, they may unknowingly contact a fraudulent number instead of the legitimate one. The scammer, posing as a support representative, then extracts personal details or directs the victim to install malicious software.

Calls requesting remote access to devices

Fraudsters often call individuals, claiming to be from reputed organizations such as banks, internet service providers, or tech firms like Microsoft and Google. They insist that the victim's device has been compromised by malware and offer to 'fix' it by remotely accessing the system using applications like AnyDesk or TeamViewer. Once access is granted, scammers can steal sensitive data, install spyware, or even take complete control of financial transactions.

Claims of 'Suspicious Activity' to steal credentials

Another prevalent strategy is the fear-based approach, where scammers claim that suspicious transactions have been detected in the victim's bank account. They instruct the victim to confirm their identity by providing login credentials, one-time passwords (OTPs), or card details. Under pressure, many unsuspecting users comply, only to realize later that their accounts have been drained.

Red flags to watch For

Recognizing the warning signs of a tech support or customer service scam can help individuals avoid falling prey to these fraudulent schemes. Here are some key red flags:

Requests to install remote access apps (AnyDesk, TeamViewer)

No legitimate customer support representative will ask a user to install remote access software to resolve an issue. If someone insists on this, it is a clear indication of a scam.

Unsolicited calls about account security issues

Banks and tech companies do not make unsolicited calls to inform users about security breaches. Any unexpected call warning of an issue and urging immediate action should be treated with suspicion.

Asking for OTPs or card details

Financial institutions explicitly warn customers never to share

OTPs, CVV numbers, or other banking credentials. If someone asks for this information over a call or message, it is undoubtedly a scam.

How to protect yourself?

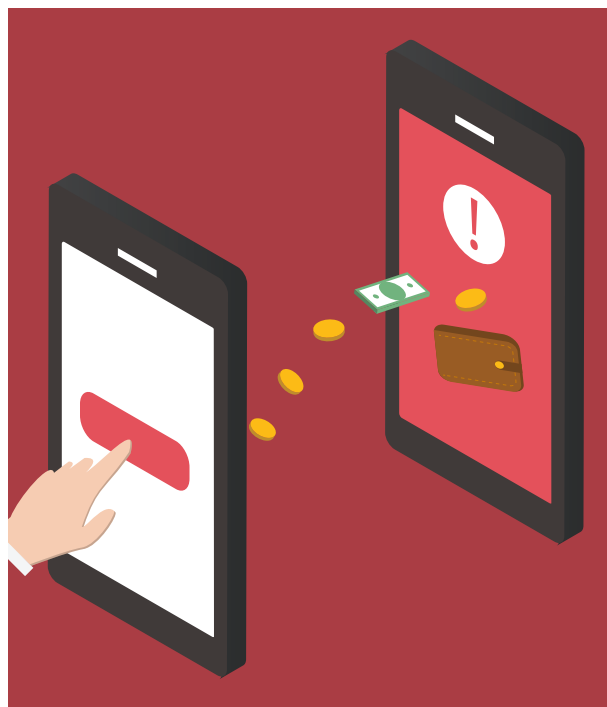
While tech support and customer service scams are becoming increasingly sophisticated, adopting a few key practices can help individuals safeguard their personal and financial information.

Contact customer support only via official channels

Always verify customer service numbers from the official website of the company. Avoid relying on numbers found on third-party websites or social media posts.

Never share device access remotely

No legitimate customer support representative will request remote access to your device. If anyone asks you to install remote access software, terminate the call immediately.



Reporting fraudulent numbers to authorities

If you come across a fake helpline number or receive a suspicious call, report it to the authorities immediately. In India, fraud cases can be reported to the National Cyber Crime Portal (cybercrime.gov.in) or the RBI's fraud reporting platform.

By staying informed and exercising caution, individuals can protect themselves from tech support and customer service impersonation scams. Awareness and vigilance are the best defenses against such fraudulent activities. 